

Gord Waldner, Postmedia News

The University of Saskatchewan has “reconsidered” its decision on Robert Buckingham, who was fired and stripped of tenure earlier this week for speaking out against cuts, and will offer him a tenured faculty position.

### **Robyn Urback: University of Saskatchewan president needs a lesson in Free Speech 101**

Usually when we hear stories about free speech being snuffed out on campus, the students are the ones doing the snuffing. Acting as self-appointed “safe space” police, students have shut down lectures on everything from men’s issues to abortion; sexuality and politics. Some over-enthused students at Queen’s University — obviously naive to the nature paradox — even went so far as to shut down a “free speech” wall on campus last year.

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However, he will not be allowed to return to the leadership position he was previously in.

Buckingham was fired Wednesday for speaking out against the university's plan to cut jobs as part of a move to save \$25-million, sparking outrage from students,

faculty and politicians.

In a lengthy statement, the university both defended the firing and attempted to walk back their decision.

“Academic freedom and tenure are sacrosanct at the University of Saskatchewan. This case, however, is not about academic freedom. Dr. Buckingham was removed from his executive director position for acting contrary to the expectations of his leadership role,” University of Saskatchewan president Ilene Busch-Vishniac said in a statement Thursday.

“Dr. Robert Buckingham, who was terminated from his position on May 14, will not return to that leadership position. He will, however, be offered a tenured faculty position. The confusion on this issue stems from differing interpretations based on his contract. Because we hold tenure in high regard, we will immediately reverse that part of our initial decision.”

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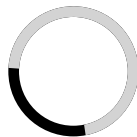
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Busch-Vishniac says there was no “lifetime” ban of Buckingham, which he had claimed.



The decision came after widespread outrage, which included a planned meeting between the university board and Saskatchewan Premier Brad Wall and a demand for Buckingham to be reinstated from Canada’s association of professors.

“Open discussion and debate is at the heart of the university,” CAUT executive director James Turk wrote in a letter to Busch-Vishniac. “Firing a dean and

tenured full professor because he publicly disagreed with your plans for the university is an intolerable attack on academic freedom and proper university governance.”

Buckingham, the former executive director of the School of Public Health, spoke out Tuesday about the university’s overhaul plan called TransformUS. He said Busch-Vishniac told senior leadership not to speak out in public against the plan.

“Her remarks were to the point: she expected her senior leaders to not ‘publicly disagree with the process or findings of TransformUS’; she added that if we did our ‘tenure would be short,’” Buckingham wrote in a letter to the provincial government and the NDP.

Busch-Vishniac said the university was on the “receiving end of inaccurate and undeserved criticisms launched from across the country.”

“The debate that is raging confuses Dr. Buckingham’s former role as executive director of the School of Public Health with the academic freedom associated with that of a tenured faculty member.”

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